

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 623

By Lynn

A RESOLUTION to recognize Williamson Chapel CME Church on the occasion of its 175th anniversary.

WHEREAS, the churches of our nation have been an integral part of our history as a people and have had an unparalleled impact in forming and maintaining a stable and just society; and

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that we should recognize those venerable religious institutions and their congregations who, through their unflagging capacity for love, dedication of spirit, and faith in God, strive to enrich the lives of people in their communities; and

WHEREAS, one such dynamic community of faith is that of Williamson Chapel Christian Methodist Episcopal (CME) Church in Wilson County, whose members will celebrate the church's 175th anniversary this year; and

WHEREAS, Williamson Chapel CME Church is located in one of the oldest Black American communities in West Wilson County, known as the Needmore community, on land that was at one time part of one of the larger plantations in the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, between 1840 and 1850, the Mastman family gave an acre of land to be used to construct both a church and a school for Needmore community residents; the deed was registered in the name of Williamson Chapel CME Church trustees Cal Gordon, husband of Lizzie Williamson (daughter of Richard and Chaney Williamson), Hiram Williamson (brother of Richard Williamson), Joe Johnson, Jessie Parker, and John Horton; and

WHEREAS, after eight generations, the present-day descendants of Richard and Chaney Williamson continue to reside in the Needmore community and surrounding areas; and

WHEREAS, around 1896, the old log church was torn down, and an oblong frame building was erected a few feet from the original edifice; the new structure had no foundation,

was supported on stilts, and had no electricity—kerosene lamps were hung on the walls inside for lighting, and two large potbelly coal stoves were used as sources of heat; and

WHEREAS, over the years, the church has benefited from the inspired leadership of several ministers, including Reverend A.J. Parker, Reverend A.H. Jenkins, Reverend D.R. Wiles, Reverend W.R. Potter, Reverend E. Wiley, and Reverend D.L. Wein; and

WHEREAS, in 1936, Reverend John H. Britton was assigned to Williamson Chapel, and during his tenure with the church, which lasted until his retirement in 1961, he was a mentor to those throughout the community and brought overall renewal to the church; under his leadership, the building was reconstructed using stone, electricity was installed, and the church's first choir was instated; in the 1960s, a choir room and a pastor's study were added to the rock structure, and electric heat was eventually installed; and

WHEREAS, ministers after Reverend Britton include Reverend Clarence Bagwell, Reverend Frank Hudson, Reverend Dr. Solomon Shannon, Reverend Wiley Hatchett, Reverend George Coleman, Jr., Reverend Raymond Sommerville, Sr., Reverend T.R. Crosslin, and Reverend Frederick L. Braddock, Sr.; and

WHEREAS, in 1984, Reverend George W. Coleman was assigned to Williamson Chapel CME Church; under his leadership, the congregation experienced great spiritual and physical growth, and the church purchased its first parsonage, organized its first library, and held its first retreat. Reverend Coleman's efforts to preserve the two-room school built near the church in 1936 are today continued by the Williamson Chapel Historic Committee; and

WHEREAS, in 1989, Reverend Frederick Braddock was assigned to Williamson Chapel; the church continued to grow under his leadership, and new ministries were organized and implemented, including the male chorus, missionary choir, and men's fellowship. Strong emphasis was placed on children and youth ministry, and several youth organizations were organized, such as the children and youth choirs and the Leaders of Tomorrow; and

WHEREAS, Reverend Braddock also oversaw the installation of padded pews, new windows, full-length glass doors, and new carpet, as well as the addition of a new piano and the advent of drums during services and renovation of the bathrooms and the parsonage, which was paid in full; during his tenure, the land and former elementary school were deeded to the trustees of the church; and

WHEREAS, beginning in July 1998, Reverend Woodrow Harris, Jr., led the church to expand its program offerings to include tutoring, book club, computer classes, etiquette classes, field trips for children and seniors, and workshops on CPR, home buying, and personal finance; he also oversaw the purchase of additional land for church expansion; and

WHEREAS, after a groundbreaking on April 17, 2005, the congregation moved into its new sanctuary on December 18th of the same year, and the former sanctuary, which was approved for the National Register of Historic Places, became the expanded multi-purpose facility; and

WHEREAS, the current pastor of Williamson Chapel CME Church, Reverend Dr. Lynn Hargrow, Sr., has served in this capacity since July 2012, implementing his vision of training, educating, and developing a greater awareness and desire for spiritual growth and outreach, making Williamson Chapel a more purpose-driven church; and

WHEREAS, as the church celebrates 175 years of service, it continues to be a light in the community, and the devout members of the congregation have faithfully striven to carry out God's work in the world; and

WHEREAS, Williamson Chapel CME Church is truly one of the great religious institutions and catalysts for positive spiritual change in our State and nation, and the members of this exceptional congregation should be appropriately honored for their exemplary service to their fellow Christians and the good people of Tennessee; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we join in the celebration of the 175th anniversary of Williamson Chapel CME Church, thank the good people of this congregation and their ministers for their notable service to their Lord and the State of Tennessee, and wish them much continued success and happiness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.